KPPSC PMS • EUROPEAN HISTORY (PAPER II: 1914–1960) ## QUESTION 4: THE RUSSIAN REVOLUTIONS (1917), LENIN'S LEADERSHIP & NEP

EXECUTIVE EXAM METADATA - **EXAM QUESTIONS LINKED: 2025 Q.2: 'Investigate the Russian Revolution, detailing the causes of the Bolshevik seizure of power, the subsequent civil war, and the consolidation of a totalitarian state under Lenin and Stalin.' 2018 Q.2: 'Write a detailed note on the Russian Revolution (1917) and bring out its causes and results.' 2016 Q.1: 'Elaborate in detail on the Bolshevik Revolution in Tsarist Russia and evaluate the role of Lenin as a revolutionary leader.' - **SYLLABUS TOPIC:** Paper II — Section 4: Marxism & The Soviet Union — February and October Revolutions (1917), Lenin's Leadership, War Communism & NEP - **ALLOCATED MARKS / TIME:** 20 Marks | 35 Minutes | Standard Word Count: ~650–700 words - **HISTORIOGRAPHICAL THESIS:** The Russian Revolution of 1917 was a two-act historical cataclysm ignited by the structural exhaustion of Tsarist autocracy in total war; while the spontaneous February Revolution dismantled Romanov dynastic legitimacy only to construct an unstable 'Dual Power' deadlock, Vladimir Lenin's vanguard party discipline, tactical flexibility ('Peace, Land, and Bread'), and Leon Trotsky's military execution seized power in October, cementing the Soviet state through the coercive terror of War Communism and the pragmatic economic compromise of the New Economic Policy (NEP).**

📌 **EXAM ESSENTIAL TAKEAWAY > • The Dual Revolutions: February 1917 was a leaderless, spontaneous explosion of bread riots in Petrograd, industrial strikes, and soldier mutinies that forced Tsar Nicholas II's abdication. October 1917 was a disciplined, highly planned coup d'état executed by Lenin's Bolshevik minority through Trotsky's Military Revolutionary Committee. > > • The Fatal Blunders of the Provisional Government: Led by Prince Lvov and later Alexander Kerensky, the Provisional Government committed two mortal errors: (1) continuing Russia's disastrous participation in World War I to honor Allied treaties, and (2) postponing land redistribution until a democratically elected Constituent Assembly met. This alienated the peasant-soldier masses. > > • The Genius of Lenin's April Theses: Upon returning from Swiss exile, Lenin broke with orthodox Menshevik Marxism (which demanded a prolonged capitalist stage) by declaring that the bourgeois revolution was over. He demanded 'All Power to the Soviets' and coined the irresistible populist slogan 'Peace, Land, and Bread.' > > • The Kornilov Catalyst (August 1917): General Lavr Kornilov's abortive right-wing military coup compelled Kerensky to liberate and arm imprisoned Bolshevik Red Guards; this fatally exposed government impotence and gave Bolsheviks the majority in the Petrograd and Moscow Soviets. > > • From War Communism to NEP: War Communism (1918–1921) nationalized all industry, banned private commerce, instituted brutal grain requisitioning (prodrazvyorstka), and unleashed Cheka Red Terror, winning the Civil War against the Whites but causing the catastrophic 1921 famine. Following the Kronstadt Sailors' Mutiny (March 1921), Lenin pragmatically executed a tactical retreat with the New Economic Policy (NEP), re-introducing small-scale capitalism and market grain sales while retaining state control over the 'commanding heights' (banking, heavy industry, foreign trade). >**

---

1. CONCEPTUAL MIND MAP & THEMATIC PATHWAY ```

==========

STRUCTURAL COLLAPSE (FEB 1917) DUAL POWER & BOLSHEVIK SURGE OCTOBER COUP & CONSOLIDATION

==========

[WWI Military Carnage & Tannenberg]--> [Tsar Nicholas II Abdicates] --> [Oct 1917: Red Guards Take Power] [Petrograd Bread Riots & Strikes] --> [Provisional Govt vs. Soviet] --> [Decrees on Peace and Land] [Garrison Mutiny & Rasputin Rot] --> [Kerensky Keeps Fighting WWI] --> [Brest-Litovsk Exit from WWI] --> [Lenin's April Theses] --> [Civil War & War Communism] --> [Kornilov Coup Arms Bolsheviks]--> [Kronstadt Revolt --> NEP 1921]

==========

```

---

2. CHRONOLOGICAL MILESTONES & DIPLOMATIC DATES | Date / Year | Event / Action | Historical & Exam Significance | |---|---|---| | **Feb 23–Mar 2, 1917 | The February Revolution | International Women's Day strikes turn into armed mutiny; Tsar Nicholas II abdicates; Provisional Government formed. | | **April 16, 1917** | Lenin's Return to Petrograd | Arrives at Finland Station; publishes April Theses: 'All Power to the Soviets' and 'No support for Provisional Govt.' | | **July 1917** | The July Days & Kerensky's Rise | Spontaneous armed worker-soldier uprising fails; Bolsheviks suppressed; Lenin flees to Finland; Kerensky becomes Premier. | | **Aug 1917** | The Kornilov Affair | General Kornilov marches on Petrograd; Kerensky arms Bolshevik Red Guards; Bolsheviks emerge as saviors of revolution. | | **Oct 25 (Nov 7), 1917** | The October Revolution | Trotsky's Military Revolutionary Committee seizes telephone exchanges, railway stations, and storms the Winter Palace. | | **March 3,**

1918 | Treaty of Brest-Litovsk | Bolsheviks sign humiliating peace with Germany, surrendering Ukraine, Baltic states, and 34% of Russia's population. | | **1918–1921** | Russian Civil War & War Communism | Trotsky organizes Red Army; defeats White Armies and 14 foreign interventionist nations; Red Terror crushed dissent. | | **March 1921** | Kronstadt Mutiny & NEP Introduced | Red Sailors rebel demanding 'Soviets without Bolsheviks'; crushed by Trotsky; Lenin pivots to New Economic Policy. | | **Dec 1922** | Formation of the USSR | Treaty on the Creation of the Union of Soviet Socialist Republics officially establishes the Soviet Union. | | **Jan 21, 1924** | Death of Vladimir Lenin | Lenin dies following a series of strokes; power struggle between Stalin and Trotsky erupts. |**

3. THE 20-MARK MASTER MODEL ESSAY (~650 WORDS)

Introduction: The Two Acts of the 1917 Upheaval The Russian Revolution of 1917 stands as the most consequential sociopolitical rupture of the twentieth century, liquidating three centuries of Romanov dynastic autocracy and establishing the world's first Marxist-Leninist state. In the historiographical debate, while Soviet historiography historically sanctified 1917 as an inevitable, heroic uprising of the united proletariat under the Bolshevik banner, Western revisionist and liberal scholars such as Richard Pipes, Sheila Fitzpatrick, and Orlando Figes emphasize the profound distinction between the February and October upheavals. February was a genuine, leaderless popular implosion born of total military exhaustion and domestic starvation, whereas October was a brilliantly coordinated insurrection executed by a disciplined vanguard party. Vladimir Lenin's decisive contribution lay in his ideological audacity and tactical pragmatism: by discarding classical Marxist dogma, exploiting the democratic vacuum of the Provisional Government, and navigating the desperate transition from War Communism to the New Economic Policy (NEP), Lenin transformed revolutionary theory into permanent state power.

The Structural Roots: Tsarist Autocracy and the Crucible of World War I The collapse of the Romanov Empire was engineered fundamentally by the strain of industrialized total war upon an archaic, semi-feudal political system. By 1917, Russia had mobilized fifteen million men into a corrupt, poorly equipped military machine. Disastrous defeats at Tannenberg and the Masurian Lakes, accompanied by the Great Retreat of 1915, resulted in over five million Russian casualties. Tsar Nicholas II's disastrous decision in September 1915 to assume personal command of the army inextricably tied the monarchy's prestige to military slaughter, leaving the domestic administration in Petrograd in the hands of the German-born Tsarina Alexandra and the scandalous faith-healer Grigori Rasputin.

On the home front, the conversion of railway lines to military transport starved major urban centers of grain and fuel. Hyperinflation soared by 400 percent, real wages collapsed, and bread rationing provoked existential desperation among urban factory workers. On February 23, 1917 (International Women's Day), bread riots in Petrograd ignited a general strike. When the elite Petrograd military garrison refused to shoot demonstrators and actively joined the strikers on February 27, the imperial coercive apparatus evaporated. Deserted by his generals, Nicholas II abdicated on March 2, ending Romanov rule.

The Dilemma of Dual Power: The Fatal Errors of the Provisional Government In the vacuum left by the autocracy, an inherently unstable constitutional compromise emerged known as 'Dual Power' (Dvoyevlastiye). Formal legal authority rested with the Provisional Government—a coalition of liberal Cadets and moderate socialists led initially by Prince Georgy Lvov and later Alexander Kerensky. However, actual coercive control and popular legitimacy resided with the Petrograd Soviet of Workers' and Soldiers' Deputies, whose revolutionary 'Order No. 1' stripped military officers of authority and placed weapons under elected soldier committees.

The Provisional Government committed two catastrophic strategic blunders that doomed it to destruction. First, constrained by national pride and financial dependence on British and French loans, it insisted on continuing the war against Germany, launching the disastrous Kerensky Offensive in June 1917, which produced 400,000 casualties and triggered mass desertions. Second, guided by bourgeois legalism, it refused to sanction peasant seizures of noble estates, insisting that agrarian redistribution must await the convocation of a Constituent Assembly. Consequently, the government alienated the two most powerful social forces in Russia: soldiers desperate for peace and peasants hungry for land.

Lenin's Intervention: The April Theses and the Seizure of October Vladimir Lenin recognized that the Provisional Government had paralyzed itself. Returning from Swiss exile via the famous German 'sealed train' in April 1917, Lenin stunned fellow Bolsheviks by issuing the 'April Theses.' Rejecting the orthodox Marxist belief that Russia must complete a prolonged bourgeois-democratic capitalist phase before attempting socialism, Lenin argued that the imperialist world war had created the weakest link in Russia, allowing the proletariat to leap directly to socialist revolution. He coined two electrifying slogans that resonated across the empire: 'All Power to the Soviets' and 'Peace, Land, and Bread.'

The turning point arrived with the Kornilov Affair in August 1917. When the conservative Commander-in-Chief General Lavr Kornilov attempted a military coup d'état to crush the soviets, Kerensky panicked and appealed to the Bolsheviks, releasing imprisoned leaders and distributing forty thousand rifles to Bolshevik Red Guards. The coup dissolved without bloodshed, but the political fallout was fatal: Kerensky was discredited as an accomplice to reaction, while the Bolsheviks were celebrated as the saviors of the revolution, winning majorities in the Petrograd and Moscow Soviets. On the night of October 24–25, 1917, under the operational military genius of Leon Trotsky, Red Guards systematically seized key communications, bridges, and utilities, surrounding and storming the Winter Palace with minimal casualties. At the Second Congress of Soviets, Lenin proclaimed Soviet power and immediately issued the Decree on Peace (demanding immediate armistice) and the Decree on Land (legitimizing peasant land seizures).

Consolidation of the Dictatorship: War Communism, Red Terror, and the Civil War Having captured power, the Bolsheviks faced immediate existential threats. In March 1918, Lenin insisted on signing the humiliating Treaty of Brest-Litovsk with Germany, sacrificing a third of Russia's population and fertile grain lands to buy 'breathing space' for the revolution. Between 1918 and 1921, the nascent Soviet state was plunged into a catastrophic Civil War, pit against the counter-revolutionary 'White' armies (commanded by Kolchak, Denikin, and Wrangel) backed by military interventions from fourteen foreign powers, including Britain, France, the US, and Japan.

To survive, Lenin and Trotsky mobilized society under the brutal regime of 'War Communism.' All private enterprise was banned, large industries were nationalized, strikes were outlawed under military discipline, and armed detachment squads enforced the ruthless requisitioning of peasant grain (prodrazvyorstka). To eliminate internal class enemies, Felix Dzerzhinsky's political police (the Cheka) unleashed the 'Red Terror,' executing an estimated 200,000 suspected counter-revolutionaries, including the imperial family at Yekaterinburg in July 1918. Through Trotsky's creation of a three-million-man disciplined Red Army (employing former Tsarist officers monitored by political commissars), the Bolsheviks crushed the fragmented White armies by 1921.

The Strategic Retreat: Kronstadt and the New Economic Policy (NEP) While War Communism secured military victory, it devastated the Russian economy. By 1921, industrial output was merely twenty percent of its 1913 level, peasant production plummeted in protest against requisitioning, and a catastrophic drought ignited a horrific famine across the Volga basin that claimed five million lives. The breaking point arrived in March 1921 when the sailors of the Kronstadt naval fortress—the 'pride and glory' of the 1917 revolution—rebelled against Bolshevik autocracy, demanding free elections, freedom of speech, and an end to grain confiscation.

Recognizing that the regime was on the precipice of popular overthrow, Lenin ruthlessly crushed the Kronstadt rebellion with Red Army troops, but immediately executed an astonishing economic pivot. At the Tenth Party Congress (March 1921), Lenin introduced the New Economic Policy (NEP), which he termed a necessary 'tactical retreat.' Forced grain requisitioning was replaced by a fixed tax in kind, allowing peasants to sell their surplus grain on the open market. Small-scale manufacturing and private retail trade were legalized, generating a flourishing class of small traders (NEPmen) and prosperous peasants (kulaks). Crucially, the Bolshevik state retained absolute control over the 'commanding heights' of the economy: heavy metallurgy, coal mining, foreign trade, and the banking system. Concurrently, Lenin banned all internal party factions, ensuring that while economic life was partially liberalized, political power remained an iron, monolithic one-party dictatorship.

Conclusion: The Monumental Legacy of 1917 In conclusion, the Russian Revolution of 1917 was the foundational earthquake of modern international history. It dismantled a millennial empire, exposed the bankruptcy of liberal parliamentarianism in conditions of acute agrarian backwardness, and created a radically new model of state-directed ideological modernity. Vladimir Lenin demonstrated unmatched mastery of revolutionary timing, transforming Marxist philosophy from a theoretical critique of Western capitalism into an operational handbook for the seizure and retention of power. While the New Economic Policy successfully revived the devastated Soviet economy, the institutional machinery forged by Lenin—the vanguard party monopoly, the Cheka police state, the suppression of democratic dissent, and the total subordination of civil society—provided the exact totalitarian scaffolding that Joseph Stalin would ruthlessly inherit and weaponize in his 'Revolution from Above.'

---

4. HISTORIOGRAPHICAL PERSPECTIVES & SCHOLARLY QUOTES | Historian | Analytical Perspective | Exact Quotable Argument | |---|---|---| | **Richard Pipes | The Russian Revolution (1990) | 'The October Revolution was not a mass uprising... It was a classic coup d'état carried out by a tightly organized minority that exploited popular confusion and seized power to establish an unprecedented totalitarian regime.' | | **Sheila Fitzpatrick** | The Russian Revolution | 'The Bolsheviks did not create the popular revolution; they rode the wave**

of genuine popular radicalism. In 1917, the workers, soldiers, and peasants wanted direct power, and Lenin was the only leader with the political courage to give it to them.' | | **Orlando Figes | A People's Tragedy (1996) | 'The failure of the Provisional Government was that it tried to govern a revolutionary country by constitutional rules... In the absence of a strong civil society, Russian political culture was doomed to revert to authoritarian violence.' | | **Vladimir Lenin (1917)** | The State and Revolution | 'The goal of socialism is not merely the overthrow of the bourgeoisie, but the smashing of the bureaucratic-military state machine and its replacement by the dictatorship of the proletariat.' |**